Cabinet Committees

1. Why Cabinet uses committees

- **Division of labour + delegation:** reduce Cabinet's workload; examine specialised issues closely; coordinate ministries; formulate proposals and take authorised decisions.
- **Extra-constitutional:** not named in the Constitution. They operate under the **Government of India (Transaction of Business) Rules, 1961**, made under **Article 77(3)**; extra-constitutional does not mean unlawful.
- **Standing committees:** continuing bodies, but composition/functions can change. **Ad hoc committees:** temporary, task-specific; dissolved when their work ends. Historical example: **Emergency Committee during the 1962 Chinese invasion**.
- PM determines standing committees' number, functions and ministerial composition. Ad hoc committees/GoMs may be constituted by **Cabinet, a standing committee or PM**, under Rule 6.
- Usually Cabinet ministers; non-Cabinet ministers may be members or special invitees. Membership includes relevant portfolio ministers and other senior ministers; committee size varies.
- PM chairs committees of which PM is a member; others may be led by senior ministers. **Not every Cabinet Committee is PM-headed.**



Delegation reduces workload while retaining Cabinet oversight.

- Under **Rule 6**, committees can make authorised decisions as well as recommendations; not every case must subsequently go to full Cabinet. Matters reserved for Cabinet and limits on delegation still apply.
- **Cabinet may review committee decisions.** Interdepartmental matters require consultation with concerned departments; committees facilitate coordination rather than replacing it.

2. Eight committees: functions to remember

- **Political Affairs:** major domestic/foreign policy matters; intergovernmental political issues. Described in the chapter as **"Super-Cabinet"** because of its wide political influence; this is not a legal superiority over Cabinet.
- **Economic Affairs:** directs/co-ordinates economic policy and governmental economic activity; major economic proposals within its assigned remit.
- **Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC):** specified senior appointments/empanelments, including designated central administration, public enterprise, bank and financial-institution posts. It does **not** appoint every government employee or replace constitutional appointment procedures.
- **Parliamentary Affairs:** government's parliamentary business, priorities and progress.
- **Security:** defence, internal/external security, law-and-order policy issues within Union remit and atomic-energy/security matters. It does not erase State policing powers.
- **Accommodation:** policy/allotment of government accommodation for MPs, central employees and other eligible persons/organisations.
- **Investment and Growth:** investment, capital inflows, growth, exports, import substitution and ease of doing business.
- **Employment and Skill Development** (chapter name): skills, employability and workforce participation, including women. Current name: **Skill, Employment and Livelihood**.

3. Official composition update — 27 July 2026

- Official Cabinet Secretariat list retains **eight committees**. It uses **Cabinet Committee on Skill, Employment and Livelihood**, replacing the chapter's older name. Official composition.
- **PM leads six:** Appointments, Economic Affairs, Political Affairs, Security, Investment and Growth, Skill/Employment/Livelihood.
- **Accommodation:** Amit Shah heads it. **Parliamentary Affairs:** Raj Nath Singh heads it. Chairmanship and membership are changeable, not constitutionally fixed.
- **ACC:** PM + Amit Shah. **Security:** PM + Defence (Raj Nath Singh), Home (Amit Shah), Finance (Nirmala Sitharaman), External Affairs (S. Jaishankar).
- MoS participation is illustrated by **special invitees**, including Jayant Chaudhary in Skill/Employment/Livelihood and Jitendra Singh in Accommodation. Special invitee status differs from committee membership.

4. Groups of Ministers (GoMs)

- **GoM:** ministers brought together for an identified cross-ministry issue; investigates/co-ordinates and recommends. An **empowered GoM** may decide within explicitly delegated authority. Concerned portfolio ministers participate; task-bound groups may be disbanded after completion.
- These are different from the standing Cabinet Committees. Neither the number nor existence of particular GoMs is permanent.
- **Second ARC (2005–2009), Organisational Structure of Government report (2009):** too many GoMs, irregular meetings and unfinished work caused delays. Recommended **selective use, clear mandates, prescribed deadlines and effective coordination**; decision-making authority where appropriate. Commission chaired by **Veerappa Moily**.
- **31 May 2014:** government abolished the then-existing **9 EGoMs + 21 GoMs**, returning pending issues to ministries/departments with Cabinet Secretariat/PMO facilitation. This historical decision did **not** remove the Rules' provision allowing later ad hoc GoMs. PIB announcement.

5. One-minute recall

- **Cabinet = constitutional definition in 352(3); Cabinet Committees = business-rule bodies; GoMs = issue-specific coordination.**
- **Standing ≠ immutable; ad hoc ≠ standing; recommendation ≠ only function; delegation ≠ unlimited power.**
- **Eight now; six PM-headed; Accommodation—Home; Parliamentary Affairs—Defence. ACC = two members; Security = PM + four key ministers.**
- Mains: committee system improves specialisation/speed; safeguards are inter-ministry consultation, clear authority, Cabinet review and time-bound coordination.

Reference

- Transaction of Business Rules: Rule 6 and First Schedule.